Lesson 1: Who Am I -Identity

Goal: The learner will understand who they are as a person created in the image of God and recognize the value of their cultural heritage as part of God's design.

Supplies:

- *Paper*
- *Pencil*
- *Bibles*

Introduction:

This lesson will introduce learners to the idea that they are made in God's image, and their entire identity was designed by Him.

Opening Activity (15 minutes): Celebrity Traits Charades

On individual strips of paper, write down the names of well-known celebrities, athletes, movie stars, DJs, political figures, etc. Make sure to write as many famous names as participants, names the participants are acquainted to. Fold up the papers and place them in a bowl.

Game Instructions:

One by one, each participant will come forward, draw a name from the bowl, and describe the person using "I am/was" statements until others guess the name. The Maximum number of I am statements is 4.

Defining Identity (15 minutes)

Understanding personal identity is important for preteens because it helps them know who they are, including their unique traits, values, and cultural background. This self-awareness boosts self-esteem, making them feel confident and valued. In relationships, knowing their identity helps them communicate better and build stronger, more honest connections. It also gives them a sense of purpose, guiding their decisions and actions towards meaningful goals. Appreciating their own identity helps them respect others' differences, fostering a sense of belonging and inclusivity. Overall, it empowers them to embrace their uniqueness and contribute positively to their community.

Identity: The qualities, beliefs, personality, looks, and expressions that make a person. Explain that identity is multi-faceted and includes various aspects of our lives:

Discussion on Aspects of Identity:

Break down each aspect with simple explanations and examples. Engage students with questions about how these aspects might influence their own identity.

Physical Appearance: The way we look, including features like hair color, height, and clothing style.

Emotional Traits: Our feelings and how we tend to react emotionally to different situations.

Education: The knowledge and skills we acquire through schooling and learning.

Life Experiences: Events and experiences we've gone through that shape our views and behaviors.

Genetics: Traits we inherit from our parents, like eye color or certain talents.

Health Conditions: Any medical conditions or health issues we might have.

Family: The people we are related to and live with, and their influence on us.

Nationality: The country we are from and its cultural practices.

Race: Physical characteristics that group us into categories like skin color.

Ethnicity: Cultural factors like language, ancestry, practices, and beliefs.

Social Community: Groups and networks we belong to, like neighborhoods or clubs.

Peer Group: Friends and classmates who influence our behavior and thoughts.

Language: The languages we speak and how they shape our communication and thinking.

Religion: Beliefs and practices related to faith or spirituality.

Spirituality: Personal beliefs and feelings about the meaning of life.

Gender: How we identify ourselves as male or female.

Sexuality: Who we are attracted to and how we experience romantic feelings.

Personality: Our unique patterns of thinking, feeling, and behaving.

Interests: Activities or topics we enjoy and spend time on.

Goals: Things we aim to achieve in our lives.

Values: Principles and standards that are important to us.

Beliefs: Ideas we hold to be true.

Memories: Our recollections of past events and experiences.

Finances: The financial situation we grow up in and how it affects our opportunities and lifestyle.

Biography:

Discuss how personal history and experiences shape identity. Have students write their bios following the aspects of identity shared above emphasizing their gifts & talents, details of their cultural heritage as well as their identity in Christ.

Identity in Christ:

As young Christians it is paramount to know who God says you are. Explain what it means to have an identity in Christ. Use Bible verses to highlight key points:

- *2 Corinthians 5:17: "Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, the new creation has come: The old has gone, the new is here!"*
- *Galatians 2:20: "I have been crucified with Christ and I no longer live, but Christ lives in me. The life I now live in the body, I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave himself for me."*
- *1 Peter 2:9: "But you are a chosen people, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, God's special possession, that you may declare the praises of him who called you out of darkness into his wonderful light."*

Activity: Using I am statements have students write who they are in Christ in their work books.

Activity: In groups have the preteens discuss these questions.

1. What is the greatest lesson you have ever learnt?
2. Describe yourself as a stranger might see you
3. What makes you special?
4. Describe your favorite relative
5. Who has it easier: girls or boys? Why?

Lesson 2: Obedience

Goal: The learner will begin to understand when, how and why to show honor and respect to parents, authority figures and community leaders through obedience.

Supplies:

- ***The story of a historical or fictional figure who exemplified obedience who faced consequences for disobedience and respect (Martin Luther King Jr., Pinocchio, Abrahams obedience to sacrifice son, Moses striking the rock, the Story of Esther)***
- ***Colored pencils***
- ***Glue***

Opening Game (25 minutes)

Preparation: This game is a practice in obedience. If possible, take the children outside and have them line up and follow your directions. Have them start by walking in a queue around the compound or the yard? Give instructions on where they should walk to (e.g., "Walk from house number 10 to 15 and back," or, "Walk from this tree to that hedge"). Tell them they have to do as you say.

Game Instructions:

- Start by having the learners walk in the ordinary way. Once they have followed that direction and done it within the boundaries, give them a new direction.
- Start being silly – tell them to walk like a duck, hop on two feet, walk backward, hop on one foot, skip, walk in slow motion, take very tiny steps, walk like a lion, etc. Be creative, give at least 10 different commands.

- If you cannot go outside, have them stand and follow your directions while standing (hop, act like a dog, spin in circles, act like a chicken, etc.). Have fun giving instructions, be silly. Make sure to take note of who is following directions and who is not. Once you have finished the game, take the learners back inside and begin your lesson.

Alternative:

Simon Says game. Have the children follow instructions by using the phrase "Simon says"
before the action. If the "Simon says" phrase is not used, then the action is not to be obeyed. You can make it more interesting by doing a different activity from the one you are instructing the children to do.

Lesson Opening (20 minutes)

Begin the conversation by reviewing the game you just played. Some questions you can ask:

- How did it make you feel?
- For those who didn't follow directions, why didn't you?
- Were there specific things you enjoyed more than others?
- Why did you choose to follow the directions?
- Did you feel like you had a choice?
- How does this relate to obeying our parents or teachers?
- Do we feel like obeying is a choice?
- What makes us choose to obey and what doesn't?

Talk about how the game relates to obedience in general. Remind them that we may not always like what is being asked of us, but we often have to obey.

Obedience

Obedience to authority means listening to and following the instructions and rules set by those in charge, like your parents, teachers, and other trusted adults. It's a way to show respect and honor to those who care for you and have more experience.

Why is Obedience Important?

Safety: Adults set rules to keep you safe and help you make wise choices.

Learning: Following instructions helps you learn new things and grow in wisdom.

Trust: When you obey, you build trust with your parents and other authorities.

Harmony: Obedience creates a peaceful and loving home environment.

God's Reward:

> ***Proverbs 1:8-9:***
>
> ***"Listen, my son, to your father's instruction and do not forsake your mother's teaching. They are a garland to grace your head and a chain to adorn your neck."***

When you honor your parents by being obedient, God promises to bless you with a good and long life. This doesn't just mean living for many years, but also having a life filled with peace, joy, and good relationships.

How to Show Obedience:

1. Listen Carefully: Pay attention when your parents or teachers are speaking to you.
2. Follow Instructions: Do what you're asked to do, even if you don't always understand why.
3. Ask Questions: If you're not sure about something, politely ask for clarification.
4. Show Respect: Speak kindly and respectfully to those in authority.
5. Be Honest: Always tell the truth and admit if you've made a mistake.

Parents & Authority

God places authorities in our lives for our guidance and protection. By obeying them, we show respect and humility. Though parents are placed over you by God and in a place of authority, a young person does not have to have a submissive heart. Like the devil, you can also rebel against the created order. From this verse we see that at the root of that discontentment is pride.

The alternative is to be like Jesus, actively humbling yourself by becoming obedient to them as an act of your will. Placing yourself under the authority of another is a humbling act. Submitting to another is a humbling act. But Jesus, though equal with the Father in essence and being, willingly humbled himself by becoming obedient to the Father.